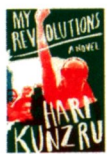


Radical Reveries

Hari Kunzru's new novel with the pace of a political thriller captures the romance of an era



MY REVOLUTIONS
by HARI KUNZRU
Penguin
Price: £4.50
Pages: 276

■ By Tara Sahgal

My *Revolutions* begins with Michael Frame in his garden, watching a marquee being built for his 50th birthday celebration. The trouble is—he isn't really Michael Frame, and it isn't his birthday. The identity he has adopted for almost 30 years is totally bogus and to make matters worse, his wife of 16 years doesn't know yet. A man named Miles Bridgeman (an unwelcome blast from Mike's murky past) has been sniffing around his new life, trying to blackmail him into full disclosure to further a political agenda. The idea of coming clean to Miranda about his real identity sends Mike into a panic and before he knows it, he finds himself in her swanky silver BMW, making a wild dash to France to locate his ex-lover, Anna Addison, who by all accounts, is very much dead.

All of this happens in the first few pages. The rest of the novel is Mike's dramatic confession—the unfolding of a secret life. Born Chris Carver, he was once at the London School of Economics, a student radical peddling Leftist pamphlets and taking part in the sit-ins of the 1960s. In 1968, he was present during the violent protest against the Vietnam War at London's Grosvenor Square, where he was arrested and imprisoned. On release, he fell into a more rabid kind of political group lead by Sean

and Anna, frenzied red revolutionaries with whom he began to inhabit squats and communes in west London.

Fuelled by drugs and a growing infatuation with Anna (so wholly committed to the collective that she rejects sexual exclusivity and the idea of romantic love), Chris morphs into a very different creature. Within this cultish group, looting and stealing are commonplace, banks and embassies are bombed, all privacy is abolished and traitor paranoia rises. As funding begins to come from large global terrorist groups, long-held beliefs fall away and are replaced by new, often contradictory and more convenient ones. Agendas shift and things get bloodier. For those wondering if this is the same Hari Kunzru who wrote

EXTREME IMPRESSIONS: Kunzru

The Impressionist, that brilliant farcical romp around the Raj, the author does allow Chris an interlude as a strung-out junkie in Pat Pong and rehab in a Buddhist monastery—though this time, it's not funny.

My Revolutions is heavy stuff, though relevant—who today isn't curious about the process of radicalisation, the actual 'making' of a terrorist? And though this novel finds its inspiration from the 'Angry Brigade' or the 'Stoke Newington Eight', a British libertarian Communist terrorist group that was responsible for about 25 bomb attacks in the early 1970s, it doesn't spew facts at us. The narrative is so well marinated in the research that you really live the morbid machinations of the group, and while you may not empathise with Mike/Chris, you will certainly

be gripped to his story from beginning to end.

At once a political thriller, a psychological profile, a coming-of-age picaresque, *My Revolutions* is also a satire: Mike Frame as middle-class house-husband in 1990s Britain, helping Miranda run a successful business selling natural beauty products ridiculously named 'Bountessence', participating in all that he once detested—capitalism, property and profit, talking about skiing and wine cellars and how "there was money to be made off the Internet"—is all as ludicrous as the misdirected rages of the Mao-spouting 'comrades' of his youth. A deliciously misanthropic read for anyone who has known the bittersweet capitulation from impractical idealism to soul-sucking compromise or for that matter, forgot that there was ever another idea. ■

